

The Powerful Catalyst of a Care Economy

The care economy refers to the production, distribution and consumption of care services, including child and elder care, healthcare, education and domestic work. It is the backbone of any society, yet it remains undervalued and underdeveloped. Recognising its potential, the ILO estimates that 269 million new jobs could be created if investments in education, health and social work were doubled by 2030. Although India recognises its importance, the country's care economy has largely remained unorganised and informal, predominantly carried out by women in their households. This presents a significant opportunity if properly harnessed, as it would allow women to contribute to the formal workforce, leading to improved gender equality, economic empowerment and social well-being. Moreover, professionalising the care sector would ensure fair wages, social protection, and better working conditions for care workers. Additionally, better access to care services would further allow women to return to work after their maternity breaks faster and reduce post-break dropouts.

India's Entrepreneurial Spirit

A decade and a half ago, the world was hit by a financial crisis with the collapse of Lehman Brothers. Referring to it, Christine Lagarde, currently President of ECB and

former MD of IMF had written "if it had been Lehman Sisters rather than Lehman Brothers, the world might well look a lot different today". Her words highlight qualities such as risk aversion, response to uncertainty, ethics and moral attitudes, and leadership possessed by women that make them better entrepreneurs. The government has already created ample opportunities in this space. Programmes such as Mahila E-haat and Stand-Up India promote women's entrepreneurship and provide financial assistance to support women-led businesses. By building on these initiatives, investing in women's education and dismantling barriers, we can create a world where women's contributions are valued, and opportunities are equal.

Create More Women Decision-makers

The government has actively recognised the need to enhance women's representation in decision-making positions and boards. Efforts are also being made to encourage greater female representation in politics, corporate leadership, and public administration, ensuring diverse perspectives and promoting gender equality at all levels. Collaboration between the government, private sector, civil society organisations and individuals is essential to create lasting change.

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Skilling for a Greener Economy

Oxford Economics estimates that a green economy will create an opportunity worth \$10.3 trillion in the global GDP of 2050. This lays out a significant opportunity to prepare and skill the female workforce to play an integral part in this transformation. We must progress on ensuring that more women are in productive and decision-making roles so that we can move rapidly and more assuredly towards sustainability in the economic, social and environmental sense.

As we strive towards that, it is crucial to acknowledge the \$28-trillion lever that women's empowerment holds for the global economy. What is imperative is the adoption of gender-smart investment strategies that utilise capital to tackle gender imbalances and promote the advancement of women as entrepreneurs, corporate leaders, employees, and consumers of products and services, and bolsters their economic involvement. As G20 Empower 2023 pursues women's empowerment as a priority and India leads the way with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's direction of not just 'Development of Women' but 'Women-led Development', we can unlock the power of women around the world to build a sustainable and resilient world. **BT**

Views are personal

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